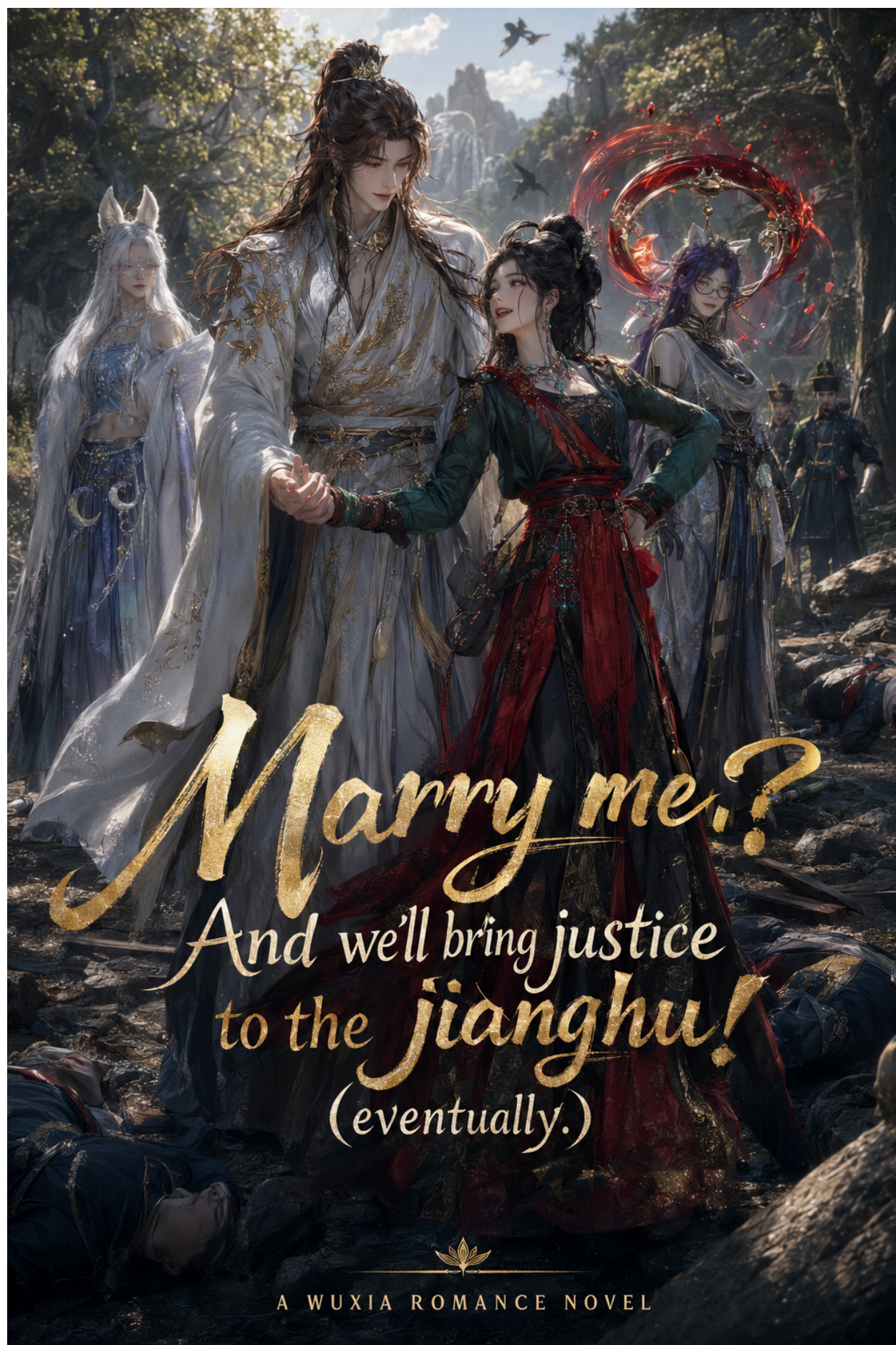




Marry me.?

*And we'll bring justice
to the jianghu!
(eventually.)*



A WUXIA ROMANCE NOVEL

PART ONE

Hekapider and Baoyu meet Zu Weiyun. Time to start reeling in a second spouse!

Notes: my tenses are not consistent and I have no editor. Enjoy!!! 😊

By hekapider

Up in the wild hills off the coast, the sun glints down through the trees. The ground is a mess of cracked stone, splintered wood, and debris.

Bandits groan on the ground where they lay strewn with the rubble, having been thoroughly wrecked.

Amongst the wreckage, standing triumphantly are Hekapider - a whirlwind of chaotic, infectious energy - and her husband, Baoyu, the long-suffering anchor of calm.

Baoyu offers Heka a steadying hand as she navigates out of the rubble. As they leave, regional officers arrive to make the arrest. The duo don't stay, having accomplished their goal. Their serious need for a bath is their new priority. As they descend the hilltop towards their horses, which had been left safely at the base, a few busybody locals approach.

"Bless you, heroes! We can never never repay you for your help. May you be blessed with never ending joy and peace."

Heka beams and accepts their kind words. Baoyu nods in respect. Neither accepts the gifts offered in their direction.

"We appreciate the gesture, but must decline. We travel too much and wish to not overload our poor horses. Please keep it for yourselves. We want for nothing."

From behind them the locals shout out, "May you share a hundred years of unbroken love, harmony, and unending loyalty!"

Heka chuckles softly and shakes her head before nudging her husband's shoulder softly... "It's a shame we can't seem to find anyone competent to join us these days. It would be nice to share the load... give you a break."

Baoyu stretched out his arms before throwing one around Heka's shoulder as they approached their horses. "We've been in the area for not even a week. I'm sure you'll find us some new trouble soon enough. Plenty of opportunities to meet more

wanderers."

Travelling with others usually begins with optimism, but there are admittedly too few who can keep pace with plans that go off the rails based on the whims and imagination of a tiny avatar of chaos wielding an umbrella.

x x x x x

Their new goal is to travel through the valley to the next town with a proper market and inn where they could take a proper bath. The mood was light and bright. The pair of wanderers joked and told stories they'd both heard from each other more than a few times, finishing each other's sentences whenever the storyteller lost their own train of thought. The chatter of the birds and rustling of creatures in the underbrush even seemed to have a joke to share.

Then, as they entered the village, like a curtain had been dropped, the world seemed to go eerily quiet. This early in the day, the town ought to be bustling... instead.

Baoyu: "The market is too dead for an early afternoon." He looks towards the few stalls that are open, "They're terrified."

Heka looks around and indeed, merchants whisper as their eyes dart around, seeming on edge and ready to bolt. Passerbys keep their heads down and rush to their destinations. Windows shuttered. Doors barred closed.

"The rumours we heard on the road. Seems the old magistrate really is bleeding them dry with new 'trading fees'... I believe you were right, my dear, trouble is heading right towards us."

Despite the serious nature of the situation, a glint of anticipation burned under Heka's skin. A stranger might find it unsettling, but anyone who knew her would know she simply loved putting so-called 'nobles' in their place...or take them out of their place. Whichever the situation called for.

As they tie off their horses outside of an inn, they continue to hear more whispers of the situation.

"...vanished. She couldn't afford their new fees and right in front of the neighbours they carted her away. It's been two days and still no sign or word of her."

"That's the third stall this week. At this rate there will be no market for them to rob, then

what?"

"Bleeding us dry. Maybe I should take up my mother's offer to go back to visit my family near the capital."

Heka and Baoyu look at each other with unspoken understanding and head inside to book a room for the week. Once they stable the horses, unload their belongings safely in their room, they settle in the common room for tea + food, which they barely touch. Instead they focus on listening...

And because too long without trouble is not possible when Heka's in town, not 5 minutes after their first sip of tea there was a sudden thud of the front door being kicked open.

There was a collective flinch of the locals as four thugs wearing cheap and worn versions of yamen uniforms strutted in, hands already wielding clubs. The man leading them had what looked to be a proper official's sword.

The thugs, which despite their official attire was a much more fitting word to describe them, strutted up to the proprietress, "Time's up! No more freebies. Pay your arrears or we'll have no choice but to take you into custody!"

Baoyu put a calming hand on Heka's hand to stop her from reacting too soon. As she looked at him he shook his head, "Not yet."

Heka, despite Baoyu's well intentioned restraint, was squirming to deal with these bad guys in a proper jianghu fashion.

However, before she could twitch there was a flurry of action! In a seeming blink of an eye, clubs and a sword were neatly piled on a vacant table and all four men were unceremoniously flung out the door. Outside they groaned in the dirt where they had landed neatly in a row.

A young woman with striking purple hair and an elegant demeanor casually returned to her table in a shadowed corner. Raising her cup to her lips she drank the remainder of her tea before leaving without a word to drag the thugs away.

Heka's eyes sparkled.

Baoyu knows that look...

Throughout the village the pair hears about this stranger.

She is Zu Weiyun. She arrived in the area weeks ago. Steps in to stop the weak from being picked on then leaves before anyone can thank her let alone give any rewards or gifts.

"A true heroine," Heka's eyes sparkle with admiration. Baoyu pats her head, "Let's not get ahead of yourself, dear."

Zu Weiyun begins to notice that Heka and Baoyu "coincidentally" appear around her. More often it's in a helpful capacity, but usually Heka is barreling in as a chaos goblin and Baoyu bringing sanity and rationality to balance the scales. The pair complemented each other well.

What catches Weiyun off guard is Heka's very direct flirtations right in front of her husband. Her husband who says nothing and just smiles fondly as he reigns in his very excitable wife.

Unable to make sense of the strangely magnetic pair, Weiyun sticks to her usual song and dance and simply makes her exits as quickly as possible.

With Weiyun's very violent reaction to the magistrate's thugs, she doesn't stay in any one village too long. She quickly moves on to the next village, sometimes skipping one or two to not be obvious in her movements.

So imagine her surprise when two weeks later a very familiar pair are suddenly in the room next to hers at the shabbiest inn she's ever seen.

Wei couldn't help but peer into the room next to hers where the door had been left ajar, "...what?"

Baoyu was sitting at the small table pouring over a map and making very neat and elegant marks of key locations. He looked up at Weiyun briefly before gesturing at her to keep her voice down. Over on the bed, starfished and half covered by the thin blanket, was Heka. Snoring.

"Booked it 3 days ago," he said matter of factly. As though it was a silly question to be asking at all while being polite enough to answer.

But Wei didn't think it was silly. She'd been so careful to keep her movements unpredictable. That this very strange pair were able to not only stay on her trail, but

predict it in advance, "...how?"

Baoyu shrugs, "...she had a hunch."

A hunch!! Wei would laugh at the ridiculousness of the situation if the reality of it wasn't sitting right in front of her. And snoring.

Fighting fate's weird sense of humour seemed to be a losing battle, so Weiyun decided that going with the tide would, at least for the moment, spare her the frustrations of trying to dodge her pursuers. It would just come down to her to keep things professional. THAT she could at least manage.

Heka was delighted to find Wei sitting at the table with Baoyu when she woke from her nap. Determined to make a good impression she moved to join them at the table...and tangled in the blanket as she was, fell to the floor instead.

Wei couldn't help but let out a small laugh at how ridiculous Heka looked. She didn't find it adorable at all. Not even a little. And if she noticed Baoyu studying her reaction thoughtfully as if he *knew* something. It was all his imagination.

Then they got down to business.

The region's magistrate, it has been learned, is affiliated with a less than honourable sect. A few high ranking members were once trained in proper sects before being expelled for dishonourable conduct. Now they recruit thugs and hire themselves out as enforcers when new policies would otherwise be unpopular. Policies such unnecessary fees for merchants, stall owners, and other business owners.

Though Wei is still hesitant, she accepts that it is a good idea to work with Heka and Baoyu. The conspiracy here is far larger than expected and the help of likeminded, though certainly quirky, heroes is indeed welcome.

While the trio is brainstorming, the weather becomes turbulent and the wind picks up. Baoyu doesn't react. Wei goes on alert. Heka pours a 4th cup of tea, and quick as lightning a white, fluffy, blur snatches the cup from her hand. A white haired woman with nine fox tails is perched elegantly on the wooden chest at the end of the bed. She sips the offered tea.

Wei was mid-reaction to go on the defensive until Heka greeted the stranger, "Shifu". Baoyu politely greets them as well "Shifu GNS". Wei relaxes... slightly.

GNS eyes Wei, clearly evaluating. She looks at Heka, "This one, eh?"

Heka smiles shyly.

GNS approaches Wei, who stiffens, and circles around her. "Good qi. Balanced." Walks around Wei. Nods in approval. "Could certainly handle your particular brand of chaos." GNS sits back down as Heka refills the teacup. "Duel now or later?"

Before Wei could question anything, Baoyu spoke up, "Later. Still too soon."

GNS nods. "Understandable. Goodness knows this disciple of mine took time to grow on you even."

GNS waves her hand dismissively, "Next time then." And quick as she arrived, she was gone.

Everything below this line still needs to be fleshed out.

Weiyun couldn't help but wonder who exactly these people were... Some kind of drunken immortal with a violent aura just casually showed up for tea with the adorable chaos incarnate while having a small talk with said adorable being's very pretty, very smart husband. (No point in denying that they are so obviously attractive.)

And what's this about a duel? Who in their right mind would duel this GNS??!

Ever observant, Baoyu seemed to have picked up on Weiyun's thoughts and without waiting for questions to be asked out loud, answered, "She's patient. No need to stress about the duel until you're ready."

"No need to stress about the duel until I'm ready," Wei parroted back in disbelief.

Heka simply nodded as if the whole situation were simply a matter of course, "It's just a formality, really. My shifu might seem as though they take it too seriously, but they aren't actually going to try to kill you or anything."

Weiyun, not wanting to dwell on the insanity of the notion, placed her hands firmly on the table, "Forget it. We're just going to talk in circles about this when we have other priorities that need our focus."

Baoyu chuckled under his breath before smoothing his hands over the map, and Heka

muttered something incoherent under her breath..... But back to task they went.

Baoyu's thoughts on strategy were quite impressive. Even with a map that lacked for detail, he was able to break down various paths for action depending on what they encountered on site. Heka was able to provide shift rotation schedules. Apparently arriving 3 days before Weiyun resulted in her wandering off to gather intel. Mostly she hid in trees to observe and eavesdrop.

"Bad Guy A is clearly crushing on Bad Guy B, but B is married and VERY in love with his wife. And very monogamous," Heka made a face at that. "Which is a shame because I think they could make it work." All that time eavesdropping and the amount of gossip she had collected... This was only one of many tangents Heka went on while she debriefed the others.

A couple of late nights followed by a day and night of rest...the trio were finally ready to take down an evil sect and a corrupt official.

Baoyu's strategy worked perfectly. It even took into account when Heka went rogue and improvised some bafflingly effective diversion with flower petals and flash bomb pellets. This confused and distracted the bad guys giving Baoyu and Wei the perfect opportunity to take them down.

Goes without saying... they totally won. Saving the day! (Fight is glossed over because I can't write that to save my life 😊)

And true to form, Wei takes off before any words of congratulations can be uttered in her direction.

As she walked along a path away from the town they had occupied together, thoughts of the past few weeks flooded her mind so much that she didn't even realize that Heka had caught up with her. Baoyu followed 10 paces behind with their horses.

"You really don't want to travel with us?" Heka asks, doing her very best not to pout.

"I like being alone." Wei answers, since this has always been her answer. Though there's a seed of doubt as to whether it's really true anymore.

"I think you'd like traveling with me. And you get along really well with Baoyu."

"Not sure I'd survive it."

"You definitely would. I only ever like exceptionally competent people."

Wei looked... uncertain. Her world view had been shaken and she had yet to catch herself up or process...

Baoyu chose that particular pause to catch up with them, "Give the poor woman some time Heka." His tone was affectionate and amused. Wei would find him aggravating if he weren't so....probably right but she'd never admit to it in front of him. At least not yet.

Heka pouted but relented. "We're heading towards the big lake a few days north of here. When you change your mind..."

"When? You're sure about that?" She wanted so badly to resist but more and more she was realizing where fate was leading her.

"I suspect we'll linger in that area for a while. Something about a drowned ghost-bride... should be fun," Baoyu mentioned casually.

Without a word he handed off a horse lead into Wei's hand before hoisting Heka up onto the second and settling himself behind her and heading north.

"And just so you know," Heka shouted back with a wave as they rode away at a slow walk, "Starburst isn't a gift. I expect her to be returned in perfect health when you catch up!!"